



MILKY WAY IN THE SPOTLIGHT

The Solar System is part of a barred spiral galaxy called the Milky Way Galaxy. In this wide-angle view, the Milky Way's plane is seen as an arc above the antennae of the Atacama Large Millimeter/submillimeter Array (ALMA) on the Chajnantor plateau in Chile. It glows with the light of a mass of distant stars interspersed with dusty nebulae and patches of glowing gas, where new stars are being born to join the existing billions that make up our galaxy.

ALMA's 66 dishes are either 39 ft (12 m) or 23 ft (7 m) in diameter and observe the sky at wavelengths between the infrared and radio parts of the spectrum. ALMA sits at high altitude—16,400 ft (5,000 m) above sea level—in a very dry region where the air contains hardly any water vapor to absorb the radiation. The thinness of the atmosphere above it and the low interference from other radio signals also make the plateau ideal for observing at these wavelengths.